

PEOPLE WHO METER
(From left) Aditi Nagrath, Akhil Katyal, Imtiaz Dharker, Nissim Ezekiel

Cares' and 'How to Be a Home Minister'—doggedly tears at the government. Explaining their anonymity, Hamraaz writes, "Who wants to be punished—or to have other projects be endangered—for a mediocre poem or even a pretty good one?" And so, we get a glimpse of the threat that poetry can harbour, and also of how, for some poets, the real work lies beyond the page.

After its winding journey, the anthology concludes with Arun Kolatkar, in some ways, only a few paces away from Ezekiel. Invoked by other poets throughout the book, Kolatkar's lines are sharp, his images abrasive, his references both pedestrian and mythic. But rather than hail Ezekiel and Kolatkar as signposts with some definitive poetic world between them, the book gives us a proposition: even in the shortest of distances, poetry can and must undergo a revolution.

For the next generation of Anglophone Indian poets, whoever they might be, this anthology is sure to be held up as a canon. But truth be told, it isn't concerned with peddling intellectual agendas. Rather, it insists simply that we read poetry capaciously and with instinctive pleasure. Of course, like with any synthesised collection, each person will (and should) find in it their own unacceptable omissions. (For me, a few major ones are Aditi Machado and Kazim Ali.) But that's the loveliest part of this so-called canonical feat. From the outset, it recognises its limitations and readily offers itself to be remade. ■

—Poorna Swami is a writer and poet from Bangalore

INTERVIEW

The Indian Poets Society

Looking at The Penguin Book of Indian Poets, *the first adjective that comes to mind is 'massive'. The anthology features 94 poets, including some who have hardly been published before and others who have largely been forgotten. Walking us through his process of selection, editor* ***Jeet Thayil*** *says one of his main concerns "was to give newer voices a chance to be heard".*

Q. This is being hailed as a definitive anthology of Indian poetry in English. How does it differ from earlier collections, particularly ones you have edited?
Inclusivity. Breadth. Informed guesswork regarding the future. There are poets from all over the world, which entails a broader vision of Indian poetry than previous anthologies. And there are essays and photographs that place writers into context. I began work on the first version of this book in 2003, for *Fulcrum* Number Four, which included the work of 53 Indian poets. There were two further iterations before *The Penguin Book of Indian Poets*, which makes it the culmination of a 20-year project. I thought incessantly about those poets whose work would continue to be vital in the decades to come.

Q. With boundaries and borders now blurrier than ever before, what was your scope in terms of defining an 'Indian' poet?
As broad as possible. There are poets in this book who left India at a very young age, for instance Vijay Seshadri, who went to the United States at the age of five. There are poets who never lived in India for a substantial period of time, for instance Monica Ferrell and Prageeta Sharma, and there are poets who never left India, for instance Gopal Honnalgere and Vijay Nambisan. But as you read them, one after the other, you will find a unity of sensibility and history. For me, that faint unity is a definition of Indianness.

How is this anthology different from past ones? "Inclusivity. Breadth. Informed guesswork regarding the future," says Thayil



RAJWANT RAWAT

Q. What did your research entail? How did you come up with the list? Also, did you have any gender/ number/ region criteria?
I went to a number of public and private libraries in various cities over two decades, including the British Library, the India International Centre in Delhi, Adil Jussawalla's archives at his home in Cuffe Parade, and my own extensive poetry shelves. I scoured the Internet. Many of the poets were suggested by Adil, whose knowledge of Indian poetry is unequalled. For the rest, I was guided by poems, not poets. And I knew fairly early on that the book would include more women than men, because some of the more interesting work at the moment is being created by women.

Q. How long did it take you to put together the anthology? What was your favourite part about working on it?
It took about two years in all, with a final, sustained effort of about three months. My favourite part? That's easy. Finishing the thing. ■

-with Sukhada Tatke